

Weekly Market View

Release of oil reserves is a good start

→ The global impact of the Middle East conflict continues to be felt through the oil market channel. Oil prices remain close to USD 100/bbl as the Strait of Hormuz remains virtually non-navigable.

→ We continue to see a 70% chance that the conflict will ease within 4-6 weeks. The release of strategic oil reserves by Developed Markets is a positive stop-gap measure as it should partly offset the lost supplies from the Middle East. Release of more reserves is likely needed to mitigate the economic and market impact of the conflict.

→ While we see elevated near-term risks, we remain constructive on equities over 6-12 months. Our preferred technology sector in the US and China has displayed defensive properties since the conflict escalated.

→ We would continue to add gold on dips given its role as a structural hedge against geopolitical risks and seek inflation protection through US inflation-linked bonds.

Hang Seng Tech index – expectations of strong revenue growth

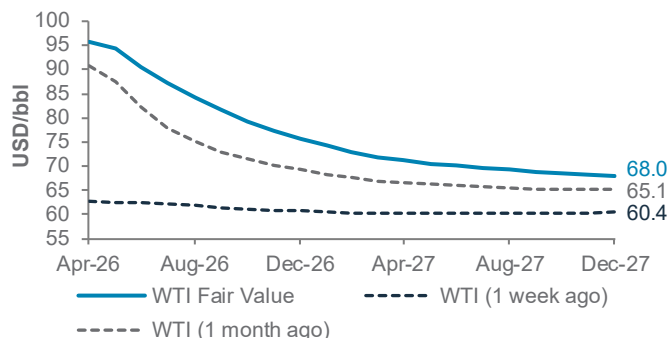
Bullish US inflation-protected bonds – hedge against rising oil price-driven inflation

Bullish AUD and gold – benefit from higher commodity prices and elevated geopolitical risk

Charts of the week: Oil prices to ease in months?

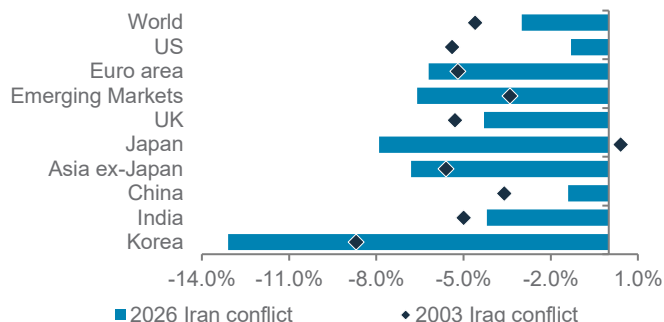
Markets are pricing less than USD 90/bbl oil by July; US and China equities have been more resilient in this conflict

US WTI crude futures price curve; today, last week, last month



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

First 10-day performance of equities in 2026 and 2003 conflicts



Editorial

Release of oil reserves is a good start

Strategy summary: The global impact of the Middle East conflict continues to be felt through the oil market channel. Oil prices remain close to USD 100/bbl as the Strait of Hormuz, through which almost a fifth of global oil and gas supplies pass, remains virtually non-navigable. We continue to see a 70% chance that the conflict will ease within 4-6 weeks. The release of strategic oil reserves by Developed Markets is a positive stop-gap measure as it should partly offset the lost supplies from the Middle East. Release of more reserves is likely needed to mitigate the economic and market impact of the conflict.

While we see elevated near-term risks, we remain constructive on equities over 6-12 months. Our preferred technology sector in the US and China has displayed defensive properties since the conflict escalated. We would continue to add gold on dips given its role as a structural hedge against geopolitical risks and seek inflation protection through US inflation-linked bonds.

Reserves release positive first step: This week's decision by the International Energy Agency members (mostly Developed Market economies) to release a record 400 million barrels out of their estimated 1.2bn barrels of official oil stockpiles is a good first step to mitigate the impact on economies. There's another 600mn of reserves held by the oil industry in these economies under government rules. The IEA release far exceeds the 182mn barrels released after the Ukraine conflict escalated in 2022. Nevertheless, the measures failed to calm oil markets, with oil prices staying above USD 90/bbl.

Release of more reserves likely needed to bring down oil prices. The amount released so far is seen as insufficient, given the supply cutoff from the Gulf producers and that it takes weeks for the reserves released to reach markets. The 400mn barrels released equals roughly 3-4 weeks of the oil supplies from the Gulf economies which are being lost due to the Hormuz strait shutdown (the daily loss is estimated at 11-16mn barrels). Moreover, almost 10% of the global oil output of roughly 100mn barrels per day have been lost since the conflict

started as Gulf producers deepened production cuts as storage tanks fill up. Given this, the market remains very focused on how soon the Hormuz strait becomes navigable again.

We continue to see a 70% chance the conflict will last 4-6 weeks. This is based on the following assumptions: a) US President Trump does not want a prolonged conflict ahead of the mid-term elections in November and will use all means (military, insurance coverage, etc.) to restart shipping through the Hormuz strait; b) Iran's military capabilities are reportedly severely depleted; and c) China does not want a prolonged conflict due to its dependence on Middle East oil. Given these factors, we expect the current geopolitical risk premium in oil prices to fade in the coming months. This view is also reflected in crude oil futures markets, which indicate oil prices dropping back to more manageable levels in a few months.

Risk of inflation impact lasting longer, delaying Fed rate cuts. Even if the conflict ends in 4-6 weeks, inflation is likely to rise in the coming months, especially in the US where inflation was elevated before the conflict started (February core inflation came in at 2.5% y/y). Given this, the Fed is likely to keep policy on hold next week and through H1. Thus, bond yields face upside pressure in the near term. Hence, we believe it would be prudent to wait for better levels to average into high quality US bonds. We prefer US inflation-protected bonds instead. We expect the Fed to cut rates eventually in H2, though, to support a weak job market (payrolls contracted again in February)

Remain positive on China, US tech sector: Global tech sector equities have displayed defensive properties over the past week, outperforming most asset classes over the past week, despite the global risk-off sentiment. We expect this pattern to continue, with solid Q4 2025 earnings reports expected from China's tech sector leaders next week. China's 15th Five-Year Plan signalled "AI Plus" and technological self-reliance as a key strategy. The Hang Seng technology index is our preferred route to gain exposure to the AI boom in China. We believe the index has significant valuation rerating potential.

— Rajat Bhattacharya

The weekly macro balance sheet

Our weekly net assessment: On balance, we see the past week's data and policy as negative for risk assets in the near-term

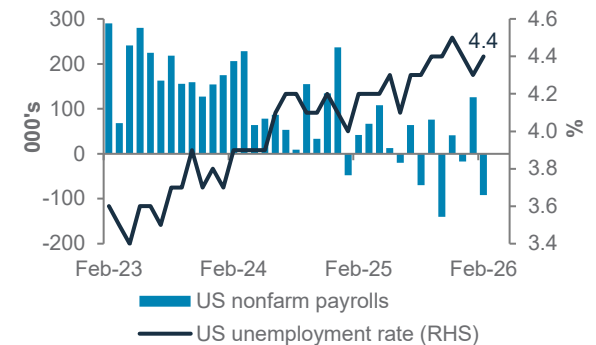
(+) factors: China's easing deflation and robust export growth

(-) factors: Falling US job creation; hawkish central banks; elevated geopolitical tensions

	Positive for risk assets	Negative for risk assets
Macro data	- US headline and core inflation came in as expected at 0.3% and 0.2% m/m in February, before the escalation of the Middle East conflict - US existing home sales and housing starts rose more than expected - China consumer and producer price inflation came in above expectations at 1.3% y/y and -0.9% y/y respectively in February, easing deflation pressures - China exports grew 39.6% y/y in February, beating estimates	- US non-farm payrolls fell unexpectedly by 92,000 in February; January's payrolls were revised lower by 4,000 - US unemployment rate rose to 4.4% in February, above estimates - US NFIB Small Business Optimism Index came in below expectations in February at 98.8 - Euro area Sentix investor confidence fell more than expected to -3.1 in March
	Our assessment: Neutral – China inflation pickup vs. contracting US job market	
Policy developments		ECB's Kazimir said rising inflation due to the Middle East conflict could force a rate hike sooner than expected
	Our assessment: Negative – Rising risk of more hawkish central banks	
Other developments	- President Trump said the Middle East conflict would be over in 4-6 weeks - Russia's Putin and Trump held a phone call on ending the Ukraine conflict and proposals to settle Iran conflict	- Iran's new supreme leader Khamenei, in his first public statement, said the Hormuz strait will remain closed - US Secretary of War Hegseth said Iran would see the "most intense day of strikes" yet this week
	Our assessment: Negative – Ongoing geopolitical tensions	

US non-farm payrolls fell 92,000 in February, defying expectations of growth and marking a significant labour market slowdown

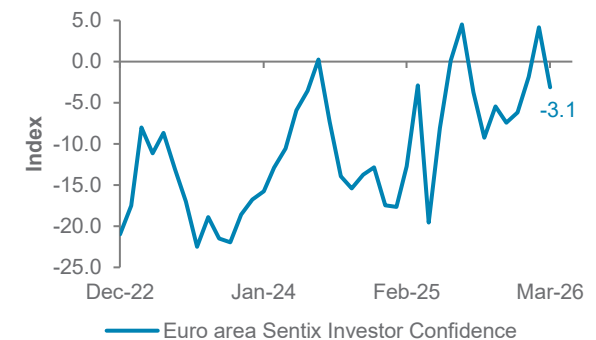
US non-farm payrolls and unemployment rate



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Euro area investor confidence fell in March, the first negative reading in five months and signalling a downturn in economic expectations

Euro area Sentix investor confidence



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

China's consumer price inflation rose to the highest level in over three years in February along with easing producer deflation

China consumer and producer price inflation



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Top client questions

Q What is your outlook for oil prices following the latest release of International Energy Agency (IEA) oil reserves?

Our view: We expect the current geopolitical premium in oil prices to fade gradually, as the IEA's emergency oil reserve release and easing geopolitical tensions should allay supply-related fears.

Rationale: Crude oil prices once again approached USD 100/bbl after Iran's new supreme leader Mojtaba Khamenei threatened a prolonged Strait of Hormuz closure. However, the IEA's decision to release a record 400mn barrels of strategic oil reserves remains a positive step towards calming concerns regarding near-term oil supply disruptions.

We still see a **70% probability of the conflict ending within a few weeks**. While the geopolitical risk premium is likely to remain elevated in the near term due to the Strait of Hormuz transit disruptions, it should eventually give way to the underlying supply overhang. With the futures curve currently in 'backwardation' – where near-term oil prices trade above longer-dated contracts – prices could face downward pressure over time.

We prefer holding US Treasury Inflation-protected Securities (TIPS) as a hedge against potential inflationary pressures stemming from the energy market volatility.

— **Anthony Naab**, CFA, Investment Strategist

Q With the US 10-year government bond yield rising, is there an opportunity to add? Or should investors wait?

Our view: We believe investors will have an opportunity to add exposure when the US 10-year government bond yield is above 4.25% – above our expected three-month range (4-4.25%).

Rationale: The 10-year US government bond yield has climbed to above 4.25%, from below 4%, after oil prices spiked following the Middle East conflict-related disruptions. Our base case assumes the conflict will last a few weeks, sustaining oil price volatility and causing fluctuations in inflation expectations and bond yields in the near term.

February's US non-farm payrolls disappointed (-92,000 jobs), with job creation remaining significantly slower since 2025. Despite higher inflation expectations, we anticipate **the Fed will cut rates as the labour market weakens further**. Investors should scale in if yields exceed 4.25%, provided the conflict does not escalate materially and prolong oil supply disruptions beyond our base case. US inflation-protected bonds remain a time-tested hedge against any upside inflation risks in the coming months.

— **Ray Heung**, Senior Investment Strategist

The recent oil spike above key technical levels highlights the extent of the geopolitics-driven rally

WTI crude oil and technicals



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

US 10-year government bond yield has reached the upper bound of our near-term range

US 10-year government bond yield and our expected three-month range



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Top client questions (cont'd)

Q As oil prices pull back, are energy equities still a viable hedge against the risk of higher oil prices?

Our view: While higher oil prices might support the energy sector in the near term, the risk-reward around increasing exposure to energy sector equities has become less attractive.

Rationale: The energy sector still offers a near-term hedge against elevated oil prices. Upstream oil and gas producers are likely to outperform downstream refiners and petrochemical companies that cannot pass on higher input costs. However, our base-case scenario assumes the Middle East conflict will be relatively short-lived. If a ceasefire occurs and the Strait of Hormuz reopens over the next 4-6 weeks, we expect WTI oil prices to retreat towards USD 60/bbl, capping further upside for energy sector equities.

The MSCI ACWI Energy Index has significantly outperformed the global equity market year-to-date (+25.8% vs. -0.4%) and has reached overbought territory, with sector valuations now over 2 standard deviations above their five-year average. Our technical indicators point to a rising reversal risk for the US, Europe and China energy sectors following this rally. While the Strait of Hormuz is largely closed, global oil supply is not structurally scarce amid large production capacity and petroleum reserves globally. This raises the risk of a significant pullback in the oil prices and energy equities if geopolitical tensions de-escalate.

— Michelle Kam, CFA, Investment Strategist

Q Major Chinese internet firms are reporting earnings next week. What are your expectations?

Our view: We expect major Chinese internet companies' revenue growth to remain robust, supporting our positive outlook on the Hang Seng Technology Index (HSTECH).

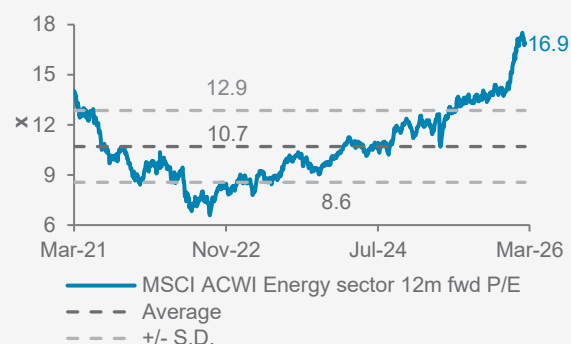
Rationale: Major Chinese internet companies will announce their Q4 2025 results in the coming weeks. We expect their top-line growth to remain solid, underpinned by expanding cloud, AI, international e-commerce, etc. Profitability will be closely watched, given increasing AI investment and intense competition. For HSTECH, consensus estimates indicate revenue growth of 11%/13% and earnings growth of 4.3%/7.5% in 2025/2026, respectively.

Policy support remains strong, with China's 15th Five-year Plan emphasising 'AI Plus' and technological self-reliance. We expect the rising adoption of AI agents to boost demand for cloud services. Our preferred route for gaining exposure to China's AI boom is HSTECH, which has significant valuation re-rating potential. Amid last week's risk-off market sentiment, we saw outperformance by major US and Chinese tech companies. We expect this trend to continue, with reassuring earnings reports from major Chinese internet firms.

— Jason Wong, Equity Analyst

Global energy sector equities are expensive after their recent rally

12-month forward P/E for MSCI ACWI Energy equities sector index



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

The Hang Seng tech index has significant re-rating potential, with upcoming earnings reports from China's internet companies being a key catalyst

12-month forward P/E for Hang Seng Technology Index



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Top client questions (cont'd)

Q Given the recent geopolitical events, is the USD's rebound likely to persist? How can investors rebalance their foreign exchange (FX) exposure?

Our view: The USD Index (DXY) is expected to consolidate near the 100 resistance level. We see an opportunity for investors to diversify their FX exposure by adding Australian Dollar (AUD) and gold.

Rationale: We believe the sustainability of USD appreciation will depend on the persistence of geopolitical risks and the Fed's monetary policy trajectory. If Middle East tensions remain elevated, the resulting oil price surge could add to inflation risks and prompt the Fed to signal fewer or delayed rate cuts. Therefore, we see the DXY consolidating near the 100 resistance level in the near term. A conflict resolution would likely weigh on the USD.

Diversification remains essential for investors. It is prudent to increase allocations to currencies with robust fundamentals and a lower correlation with the DXY, such as the AUD (given the Reserve Bank of Australia's [RBA's] hawkish stance). AUD/USD continues to show positive momentum. Gold (XAU) also remains an attractive option. Although XAU/USD has experienced a slight retreat, further downside would require an exceptionally hawkish Fed, which is not our base case. Therefore, adding exposure on dips can serve as a natural hedge against heightened geopolitical and inflationary risks.

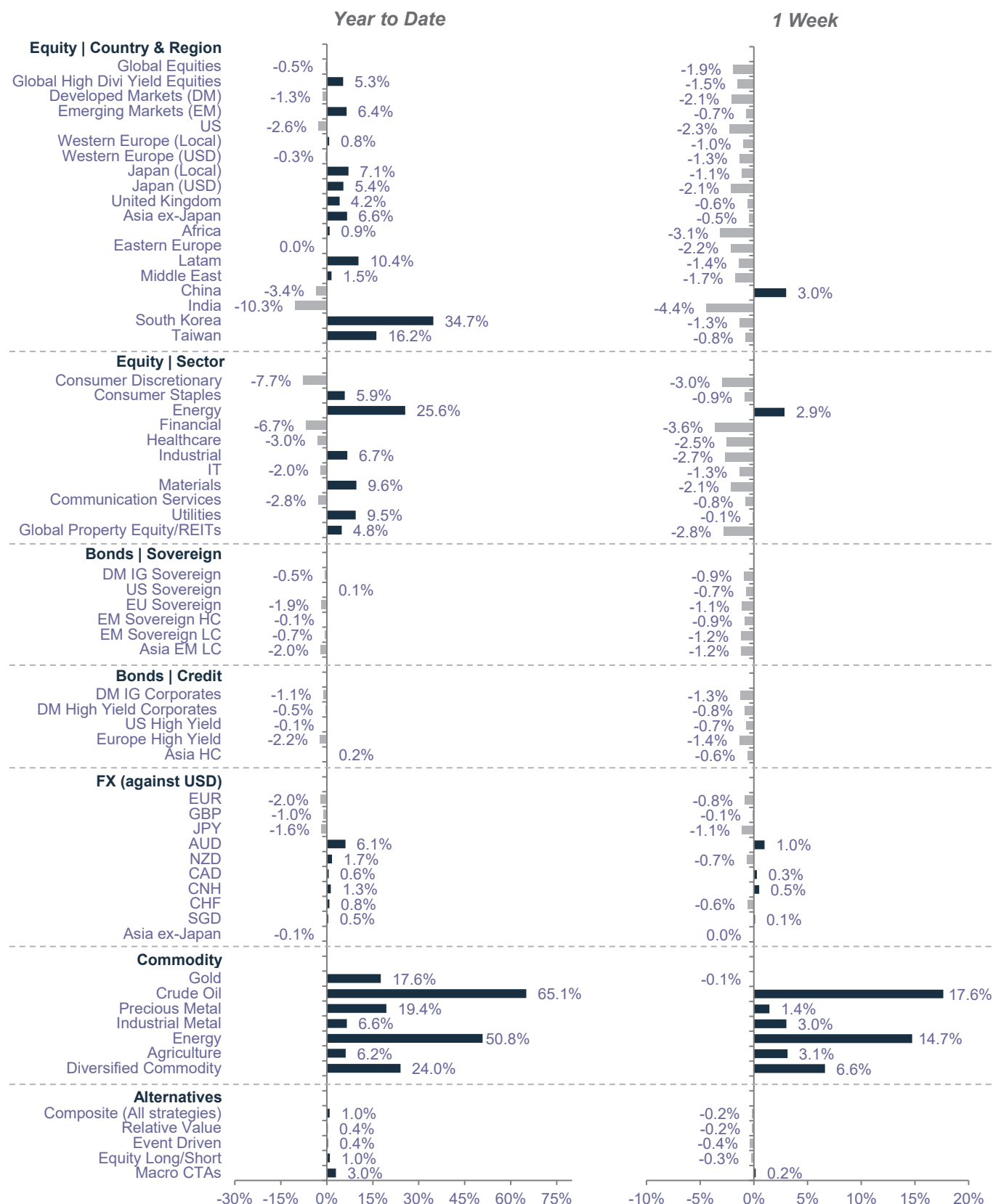
— Iris Yuen, Investment Strategist

The USD index is likely to rebound towards 100 DXY Index and technicals



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Market performance summary*



Sources: MSCI, JP Morgan, Barclays Capital, Citigroup, Dow Jones, HFRX, FTSE, Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

*Performance in USD terms unless otherwise stated, 2026 YTD performance from 31 December 2025 to 12 March 2026; 1-week period: 5 March 2026 to 12 March 2026

Our 12-month asset class views at a glance

Asset class	
Equities ▲	Preferred Sectors
US ▲	US Technology ▲
Europe ex-UK ▼	US Healthcare ▲
UK ▼	US Utilities ▲
Asia ex-Japan ▲	Europe Healthcare ▲
Japan ▼	Europe Industrials ▲
Other EM ◆	Europe Financials ▲
	Europe Technology ▲
Bonds (Credit) ▼	China Communication ▲
Asia USD ◆	China Technology ▲
Corp DM HY ▼	China Healthcare ▲
Govt EM USD ▲	
Corp DM IG ▼	Alternatives ◆
Bonds (Govt) ◆	Gold ▲
Govt EM Local ▲	
Govt DM IG ◆	

Source: Standard Chartered Global Investment Committee

Legend: ▲ Most preferred | ▼ Less preferred | ◆ Core holding

The S&P500 has next interim resistance at 6,899

Technical indicators for key markets as of 12 Mar close

Index	Spot	1st support	1st resis- tance	12m forward P/E (x)	12m forward dividend yield (%)
S&P 500	6,673	6,541	6,899	20.5	1.3
STOXX 50	5,749	5,462	6,118	15.4	3.2
FTSE 100	10,305	9,946	10,799	13.6	3.4
TOPIX	3,650	3,449	3,895	16.8	2.4
Shanghai Comp	4,129	4,055	4,200	13.8	2.9
Hang Seng	25,717	24,616	27,108	11.0	3.3
Nifty 50	23,639	22,794	25,247	18.2	1.6
MSCI Asia ex-Japan	972	915	1,041	13.0	2.2
MSCI EM	1,492	1,409	1,600	12.3	2.6
Crude oil (WTI)	95.7	65.2	122.9	na	na
Gold	5,079	4,809	5,384	na	na
UST 10Y Yield	4.26	4.03	4.38	na	na

Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Note: These short-term technical levels are based on models and may differ from a more qualitative analysis provided in other pages

Economic and market calendar

	Market	Event	Period	Expected	Prior
MON	CNH	Retail Sales y/y	Feb	–	0.9%
	CNH	Industrial Production y/y	Feb	–	5.2%
	USD	Empire Manufacturing	Mar	3.9	7.1
TUE	AUD	RBA Cash Rate Target	17-Mar	–	3.9%
	EUR	ZEW Survey Expectations	Mar	–	39.4
	USD	Leading Index	Feb	–	-0.2%
WED	USD	PPI Final Demand y/y	Feb	–	2.9%
	USD	PPI Ex Food & Energy y/y	Feb	–	3.6%
	CAD	Bank of Canada Rate Decision	18-Mar	2.3%	2.3%
	USD	Durable Goods Orders	Jan F	–	-1.4%
THU	JPY	BOJ Target Rate	19-Mar	–	0.8%
	USD	FOMC Rate Decision (Upper Bound)	18-Mar	3.8%	3.8%
	GBP	Bank of England Bank Rate	19-Mar	–	3.8%
	USD	Philadelphia Fed Business Outlook	Mar	–	16.3
	EUR	ECB Deposit Facility Rate	19-Mar	2.0%	2.0%
	USD	New Home Sales	Jan	725k	745k
FRI/ SAT					

Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Prior data are for the preceding period unless otherwise indicated. Data are % change on previous period unless otherwise indicated

P - preliminary data, F - final data, sa - seasonally adjusted, y/y - year-on-year, m/m - month-on-month

Investor diversity has normalised across asset classes

Our proprietary market diversity indicators as of 12 Mar close

Level 1	Diversity	1-month trend	Fractal dimension
Global Bonds	●	→	1.82
Global Equities	●	↑	1.92
Gold	○	↑	1.42
Equity			
MSCI US	●	↓	1.55
MSCI Europe	●	↑	1.86
MSCI AC AXJ	○	→	1.48
Fixed Income			
DM Corp Bond	●	↑	2.01
DM High Yield	●	↑	2.03
EM USD	●	↑	1.81
EM Local	●	↑	1.90
Asia USD	●	↑	1.76
Currencies			
EUR/USD	○	↑	1.47

Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered; **Fractal dimensions below 1.25 indicate extremely low market diversity/high risk of a reversal**

Legend: ● High | ○ Low to mid | ○ Critically low



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from the CIO's desk

Fortnightly series on WEDNESDAYS

Presented by

Steve Brice

Global Chief Investment Officer
Standard Chartered Bank

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Weekly Market View

Iran impact - still contained

→ We assign a 70% probability to the Iran conflict lasting only a few weeks and 30% chance it lasts for months. The market impact has been limited so far. Oil prices, the main transmission route to asset prices, have risen above levels seen during last year's 12-day Israel-Iran conflict but remain well below Ukraine conflict levels.

→ We expect oil prices to drop back to pre-conflict levels as the crisis subsides in a few weeks, given global oil reserves remain ample once Gulf oil starts flowing again.

→ The key is how soon the Strait of Hormuz becomes safe enough for oil and gas tankers to navigate, since almost 20% of the world's oil and gas pass through the strait. President Trump proposed military assistance and insurance guarantees so that shipping resumes along the strait.

→ Against this backdrop maintaining our core pro-risk allocations and building hedges against an inflation spike remains a prudent method to navigate the uncertainty.

US aerospace and defence equities – key beneficiaries of geopolitical uncertainty

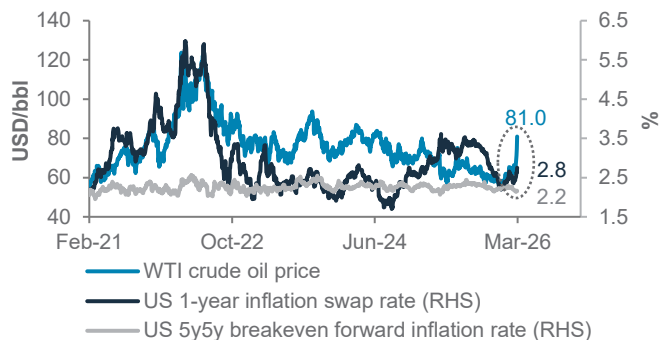
Bullish US inflation-protected bonds – hedge against rising oil price-driven inflation

Rangebound USD/CAD – higher oil prices to benefit both currencies

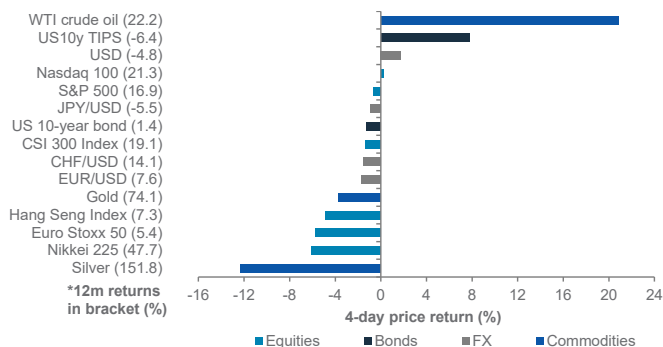
Charts of the week: Watching oil prices and inflation expectations

Oil prices have risen above last year's peak but remain well below the levels seen after the start of the Ukraine conflict

US WTI crude oil price, 1-year and 5-year inflation expectations



Performance of key assets in the 4 days* since start of conflict



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered; *27-Feb-2026 closing price to 5-Mar-2026 closing price

Editorial

Iran impact – still contained

Strategy summary: We assign a 70% probability to the Iran conflict lasting only a few weeks and 30% chance it lasts for months. Although the human and economic cost across the Middle East has been immense, the global market impact has been limited so far. Crude oil prices, the main transmission route to asset prices, have risen above levels seen during last year's 12-day Israel-Iran conflict but remain well below Ukraine conflict levels. We expect oil prices to drop back to pre-conflict levels as the crisis subsides in a few weeks, given global oil reserves remain ample once Gulf oil starts flowing again.

The key is how soon the Strait of Hormuz becomes safe enough for oil and gas tankers to navigate, since almost 20% of the world's oil and gas pass through the strait. President Trump proposed military assistance and insurance guarantees so that shipping resumes along the strait, although implementation could take weeks. Against this backdrop maintaining our core pro-risk allocations and building hedges against an inflation spike remains a prudent method to navigate the uncertainty.

Limited market impact so far: The Iran conflict has virtually halted oil and gas shipment through the Strait of Hormuz. Crude oil prices have spiked above USD 80/bbl, just above the levels seen during last year's 12-day conflict. However, prices remain significantly below the USD 100/bbl-and-above levels following the escalation of the Ukraine conflict in 2022. Meanwhile, other markets have responded in a measured way. Global equities are down 2.7% since the start of the conflict, while US equities have fallen only 0.7%, given US status of a net oil exporter. Europe and Asia equities have underperformed, since the two regions are net oil importers. The US 10-year government bond yield rebounded almost 20bps from last week's 11-month lows, while the USD index (DXY) extended gains since late January to break above its long-term (200-day) moving average.

Base scenario: In our base case (70% chance), we expect the Iran conflict to last a few weeks, rather than months, given Iran's depleted military capabilities. Besides, President Trump

is likely to deescalate if surging oil prices significantly raise US inflation ahead of November's mid-term election. US plans to provide military and insurance assistance to resume shipping through the Hormuz strait should help ease concerns about a sustained disruption. The developed economies and China have sufficient oil/gas reserves to meet demand for several months. Thus, in our base case, we see limited lasting impact on inflation. That would enable the Fed to resume rate cuts in H2 to revive a soft job market as tariff-driven inflation fades (watching February's payrolls data tonight; consensus: 55,000).

Watching inflation expectations. We assign a 30% risk the conflict lasts months, leading to a sustained rise in oil prices and surge in inflation expectations. Fed rate cuts would be pushed back in this scenario. So far, near-term inflation expectations have risen (US one-year inflation swap rate up 24bps since start of the conflict to 2.75%) but long-term inflation expectations remain subdued. However, US data is implying a revival in inflation (core producer price inflation jumped to 3.6% y/y in January). Next week's consumer inflation data will be a key focus (consensus for core inflation: 0.3% m/m, 2.4% y/y).

Maintain core allocation, build hedges: Given our outlook, we maintain our core pro-risk allocation, while building hedges against any inflation spike. USD assets would benefit from a sustained rise in oil prices, given the US is a net oil exporter. We expect US aerospace and defence sector equities, energy sector equities and US inflation-protected bonds to outperform if the uncertainty persists. We would buy gold on dips as it remains a structural hedge against geopolitical risks. Although Europe and Asia would be most impacted from any sustained spike in energy prices, given their net energy importer status, any equity selloff would create value opportunities.

Managing concentration risk in Asia: While we remain overweight on Asia ex-Japan amid earnings estimate upgrades heading into the conflict, this week's events are a reminder to manage concentration risk. Rebalancing portfolios toward quality equities and bonds remain critical in this environment.

— Rajat Bhattacharya

The weekly macro balance sheet

Our weekly net assessment: On balance, we see the past week's data and policy as neutral for risk assets in the near-term

(+) factors: Robust US services activity, steady US economic activity

(-) factors: US, Euro area inflation pickup, slowdown in China activity and economic growth target; elevated geopolitical tensions

	Positive for risk assets	Negative for risk assets
Macro data	- US ISM services and manufacturing PMIs beat estimates, while key sub-indices rose unexpectedly - US private sector payrolls (ADP) increased more than expected by 63,000 - Euro area headline producer prices fell less than expected by 2.1% y/y - Euro area unemployment rate fell to 6.1%	- US headline and core producer inflation both rose more than expected (2.9% and 3.6% y/y) in Jan - US unit labour costs rose more than expected 2.8% annualized in Q4 2025 - Euro area headline and core consumer inflation rose more than expected - China mfg. and non-mfg. PMIs below estimates
	Our assessment: Neutral – Robust US services PMI and private payrolls vs. US, EU inflation pickup, weak China PMIs	
Policy developments	- Fed Beige Book indicated US economic growth remains steady with most districts expecting slight-to-moderate growth in the coming months - BOJ Governor Ueda signalled little appetite to raise the policy rate at upcoming meeting	China set a 4.5-5.0% growth target for 2026, its slowest target since 1991, during the opening of the National People's Congress' Two Sessions
	Our assessment: Neutral – Steady US economic activity, potential BoJ rate pause vs. China's slower growth target	
Other developments	- President Trump said the US will provide military support and political risk insurance for ships operating in the Persian Gulf - US offered a temporary exemption to India to buy Russian oil in the context of Middle East supply challenges	- The US and Israel launched military attacks on Iran; Iran retaliated with strikes across the region - Trump threatened full trade cutoff with Spain over refusal to allow base access for Iran operations - US Treasury Secretary Bessent said tariffs will likely increase to 15%
	Our assessment: Negative – Elevated geopolitical tensions	

US ISM manufacturing and services PMIs beat estimates in February, with key sub-indices showing continued growth

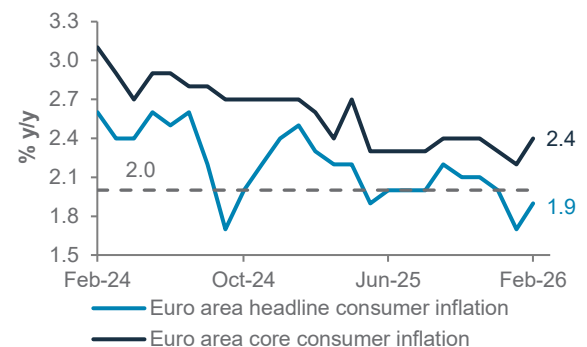
US ISM manufacturing and services PMIs



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Euro area headline and core consumer inflation rose more than expected, driven by rising service and food prices

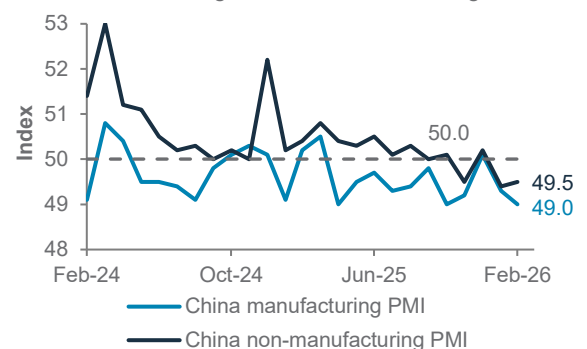
Euro area headline and core consumer inflation



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

China's official manufacturing PMI slowed to 49.0, matching the 33-month low; while non-manufacturing PMI rose slightly to 49.5, but missed expectations

China manufacturing and non-manufacturing PMIs



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Top client questions

Q How is the Middle East conflict and recent US jobs data impacting your view of Fed rate cuts and the USD this year?

Our view: *The risk of fewer Fed rate cuts in 2026, relative to our baseline expectation of three cuts, has increased. We continue to recommend investors to hedge inflation risks through US Treasury Inflation-Protected Securities (TIPS).*

Rationale: The Middle East conflict has pushed oil prices higher, **increasing inflation risk globally**. Meanwhile, January's resilient US jobs report suggests a **US labour market recovery**. These factors reduce expectations for near-term policy easing, with markets now pricing in fewer than two 25bps Fed cuts by 2026-end.

Rising inflation expectations increase the risk of a "higher-for-longer" Fed funds rate than previously anticipated. Currently, inflation swap market data shows that short-term (one-year) inflation expectations have risen more than longer-term (five-year) inflation expectations, consistent with our view that the conflict will be relatively short-lived.

The USD has strengthened as investors seek safety amid geopolitical risks, boosting the USD Index (DXY) and reinforcing resistance at 100. Although further upside appears limited as it's technically close to overbought, we still see **longer-term downside risk for the USD**. Against this DXY context, USD/CHF faces a resistance zone near 0.79.

— **Ray Heung**, Senior Investment Strategist
Iris Yuen, Investment Strategist

Q What key catalysts are you watching for your preferred markets of China and India within Asia ex-Japan (AxJ)?

Our view: *Catalysts for China include major internet companies' earnings reports in March and policy support. A potential decline in oil prices would be a catalyst for India.*

Rationale: Though China and India equities have lagged the broader AxJ region YTD, we remain **positive on these markets** for the next 6-12 months. In China, we expect internet and technology to show resilient earnings momentum, alongside a continuation of shareholder-friendly actions, including higher dividends and share buybacks. We see constructive policy support as China targets 4.5-5.0% growth for 2026 (see our Market Watch on China's 2026 NPC takeaways). Incremental reforms encouraging the shift of house savings into equity markets would also be tailwinds.

For India equities, higher oil prices negatively impact roughly 20% of the market. Thus, **a de-escalation in the Middle East, leading to lower oil prices, would be a positive**. We expect India's earnings cycle to strengthen, driven by the US-India trade deal and resilient GDP growth supported by the 2026-27 Union Budget.

— **Fook Hien Yap**, Senior Investment Strategist

Risk of markets pricing in fewer than our expected three 25bps Fed funds rate cuts by 2026 has risen

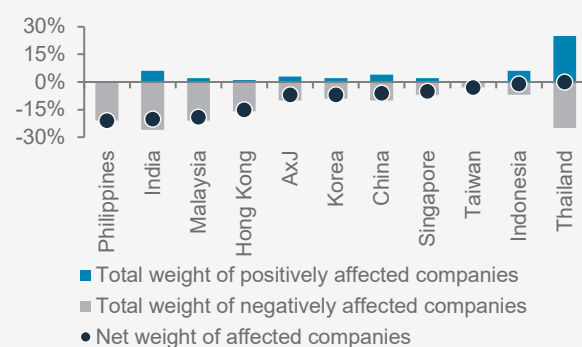
Market-implied number of 25bps Fed funds rate cuts by 2026



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

India's equity market is negatively exposed to higher oil prices, more than Asia ex-Japan on average

Exposure of Asian equity markets to rising oil price



Source: FactSet, Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Top client questions (cont'd)

Q Is it too late to add to the aerospace and defence (A&D) equities sector?

Our view: *No, it is not, given the recent geopolitical tailwinds.*

Rationale: We expect the Trump administration to pursue executive actions and foreign policy initiatives to advance its political agenda ahead of the November US mid-terms. One of the more visible ways is the series of military actions in 2026. Media reports indicate that Trump plans to meet top US defence contractors this week to discuss **accelerating weapons production**, as the Pentagon seeks to replenish inventories.

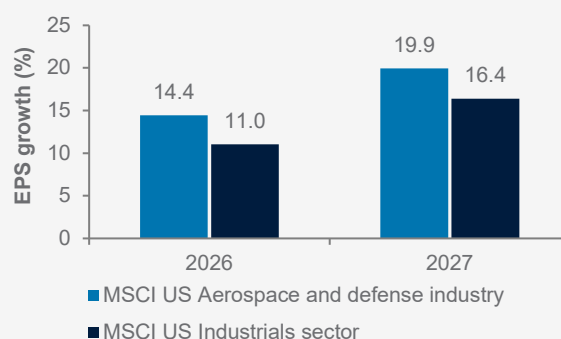
The ongoing uptrend in US military spending should continue to support demand across key A&D players, spanning both hardware and advanced technologies. We expect the strong demand to translate into stronger A&D earnings growth over the coming quarters, underpinning sustained share price performance while offering a hedge against elevated geopolitical tensions.

We maintain our opportunistic view on the A&D theme. A&D has led earnings growth within the Industrials sector, with projected earnings per share (EPS) growth of 14.4% and 19.9% in 2026 and 2027, respectively. We believe this justifies a valuation premium.

— **Michelle Kam, CFA**, Investment Strategist

US Aerospace & Defence sector earnings growth projections continue to lead the wider Industrials sector

EPS growth projections for MSCI US Aerospace & Defence industry and MSCI US Industrials Indices



Source: FactSet, Standard Chartered

Q Is the Japanese Yen (JPY) still a safe-haven currency?

Our view: *Japan's reliance on Middle Eastern oil flows limits the JPY's safe-haven status. USD/JPY is likely to stay rangebound between 154.8 and 159.*

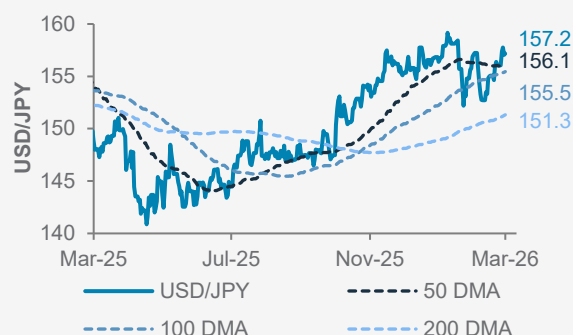
Rationale: Japan is among the world's largest crude oil importers, sourcing approximately 95% of its crude oil and 11% of its liquefied natural gas (LNG) from the Middle East. Roughly 70% of this oil passes through the Strait of Hormuz, making Japan particularly vulnerable to transit and supply risks. Given the current volatility in the region, the **JPY is unlikely to be the most reliable safe-haven currency** in the current environment.

Initially, the USD/JPY pair faces upward pressure due to heightened Middle East tensions. However, any sharp moves are likely to prompt FX intervention from Japan's government. Overall, we anticipate the pair to encounter significant resistance around 159, with support near 154.8.

— **Iris Yuen**, Investment Strategist

USD/JPY is likely to remain rangebound between 154.8 and 159

USD/JPY and technicals



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Top client questions (cont'd)

Q What is your outlook for the Canadian Dollar (CAD) amid higher oil prices?

Our view: *Despite rising oil prices, USD/CAD remains stable. We expect a trading range of 1.3540-1.3800.*

Rationale: The escalating tensions in the Middle East have contributed to higher oil prices. Should there be an extended disruption in the Strait of Hormuz, crude oil prices could surge higher. Against this backdrop, **USD/CAD remains relatively stable**. This does not imply that the CAD is unresponsive to geopolitical shocks. In fact, the CAD real effective exchange rate (REER) has increased by 0.9%, reaching a three-week high. However, the strong USD offsets CAD strength, as it benefits from safe-haven flows during periods of uncertainty. Thus, on balance, we expect USD/CAD to trade within the 1.3540-1.3800 range.

— Iris Yuen, Investment Strategist

Q What are your views on precious metals, especially with gold trading close to your three-month target, given heightened geopolitical tensions?

Our view: *We remain Overweight on gold and maintain our three-month forecast at USD 5,250/oz.*

Rationale: Precious metals initially rallied at the onset of the recent geopolitical tensions in the Middle East, with gold and silver posting one-day gains of 2.7% and 6.2%, respectively, as safe-haven demand strengthened. After the initial spike, some profit-taking emerged as the USD firmed, capping gains.

While gold is currently benefiting from its **tactical role as a geopolitical hedge**, our base case remains that the conflict will be relatively short-lived. In that scenario, we would expect gold to be driven primarily by its **structural** trends, including **portfolio diversification** and **central bank buying**, which underpin our constructive long-term view and three-month forecast of USD 5,250/oz.

In the near term, however, a key risk would be the repricing of Fed rate expectations, as higher rates typically weigh on non-yielding assets such as gold.

— Anthony Naab, CFA, Investment Strategist

The strong USD offsets CAD strength; USD/CAD likely to remain rangebound

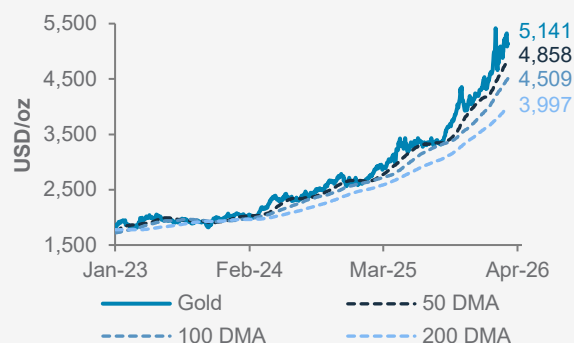
USD/CAD and technicals



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

We would add Gold on dips as it is likely to benefit from structural tailwinds

XAU/USD and technicals



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Top client questions (cont'd)

Should I be worried about private credit?

Our view: Forward-looking returns are still healthy for the asset class. We continue to emphasise careful manager selection, focusing on top-tier managers. However, deteriorating market sentiment has increased redemption requests, raising the risk of credit funds enforcing redemption limits. Our belief is that holding through this noise remains the optimal approach.

Rationale: There has been a lot of noise around private credit in recent weeks, with one major asset manager in particular seeing a massive increase in redemption requests. While the manager met all these requests and even decided to proactively return capital to investors, this, alongside concerns over private credit's exposure to software companies – whose business models are increasingly being challenged by AI – has increased investor concerns.

In our 2026 Outlook, 'Blowing Bubbles?', we identified two main concerns around private credit:

The first is the lack of transparency and the fear that challenges in private credit could spill over into the broader traditional financial sector. While we agree that greater transparency would benefit investors and regulators, we believe **the risk of a contagion to the broader financial system remains relatively small**. The private credit industry is growing, but it is still far from levels that would pose a systemic risk to the wider financial sector. Private credit raises money from investors for long periods of time and typically enforces quarterly redemption limits to protect against fire sales, which actually helps protect investors. Banks, by contrast, have to give clients their money back on demand. Indeed, it was the inability of some banks to do so during the 2008 Global Financial Crisis (GFC) that fuelled the dramatic expansion of the private credit space.

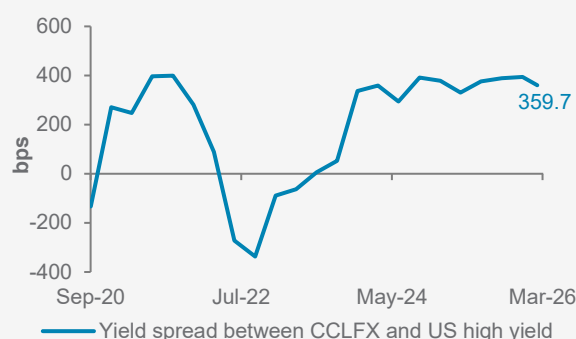
The second concern is that strong investment demand for private credit could weaken due diligence and erode risk-return dynamics. We have certainly seen increased dispersion in asset manager quality. Therefore, **some funds are likely to come under pressure and close**, dampening market sentiment and leading to even top-tier managers limiting redemption requests.

Structurally, we remain comfortable in retaining a 6% allocation to private credit in our Balanced Foundation+ allocation. The forward-looking returns remain high in absolute terms (our estimate is 8.6% per annum over the next five years) and relative to public credit (Developed Market Investment Grade credit 5.0% and Global High Yield 5.4%). However, we continue to suggest focusing on top-tier managers and being cautious about adding private credit exposure until the dust settles.

— **Steve Brice**, Global Chief Investment Officer (CIO)

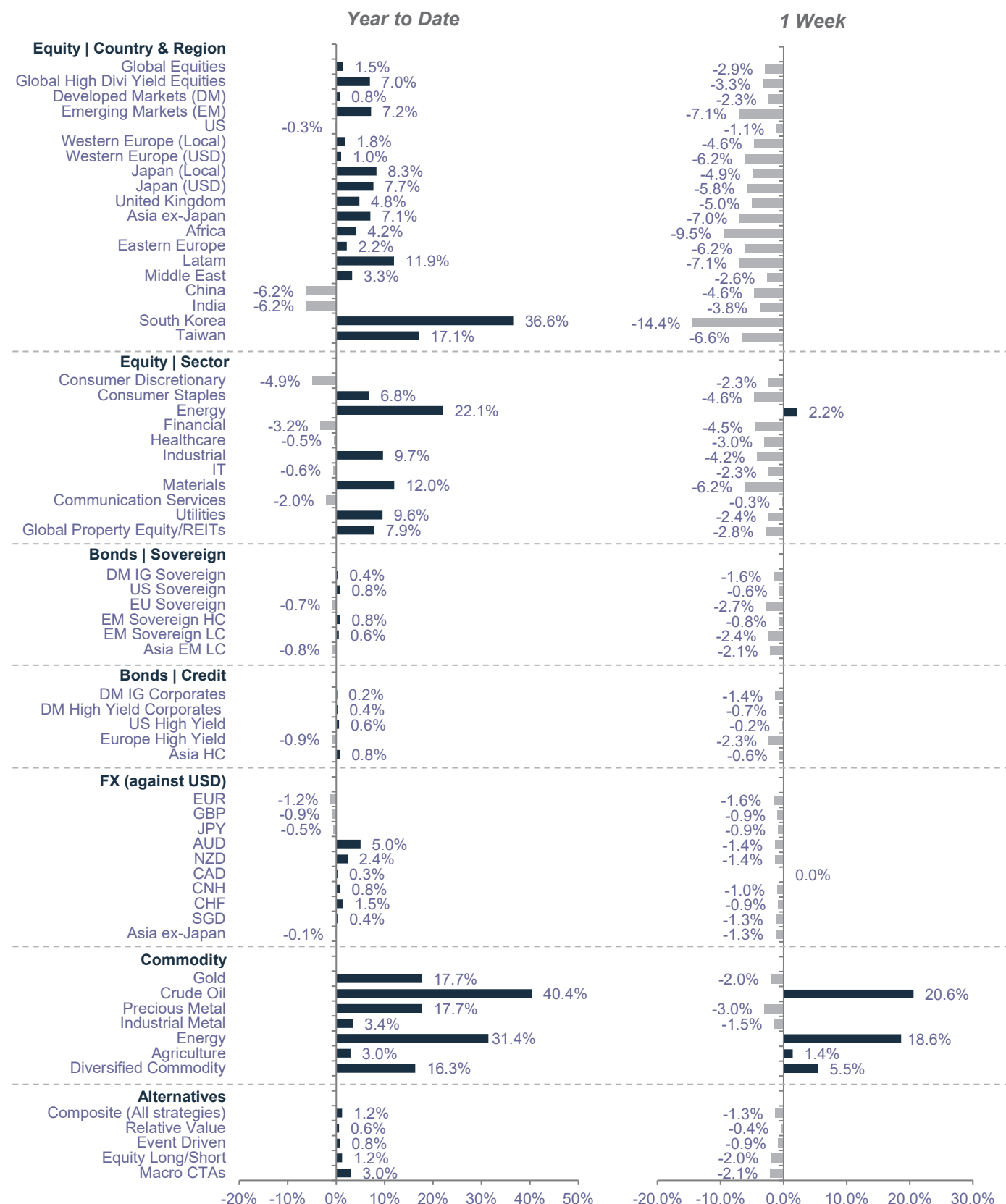
Private credit remains relatively attractive compared to public credit, although implementing via a strong, first-tier manager is key

Yield spread between Cliffwater Corporate Lending Fund (CCLFX) and US corporate high yield



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Market performance summary*



Sources: MSCI, JP Morgan, Barclays Capital, Citigroup, Dow Jones, HFRX, FTSE, Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

*Performance in USD terms unless otherwise stated, 2026 YTD performance from 31 December 2025 to 5 March 2026; 1-week period: 26 February 2026 to 5 March 2026

Our 12-month asset class views at a glance

Asset class	
Equities ▲	Preferred Sectors
US ▲	US Technology ▲
Europe ex-UK ▼	US Healthcare ▲
UK ▼	US Utilities ▲
Asia ex-Japan ▲	Europe Healthcare ▲
Japan ▼	Europe Industrials ▲
Other EM ◆	Europe Financials ▲
	Europe Technology ▲
Bonds (Credit) ▼	China Communication ▲
Asia USD ◆	China Technology ▲
Corp DM HY ▼	China Healthcare ▲
Govt EM USD ▲	
Corp DM IG ▼	Alternatives ◆
Bonds (Govt) ◆	Gold ▲
Govt EM Local ▲	
Govt DM IG ◆	

Source: Standard Chartered Global Investment Committee

Legend: ▲ Most preferred | ▼ Less preferred | ◆ Core holding

The S&P500 has next interim resistance at 6,979

Technical indicators for key markets as of 5 Mar close

Index	Spot	1st support	1st resis- tance	12m forward P/E (x)	12m forward yield (%)
S&P 500	6,831	6,696	6,979	21.1	1.3
STOXX 50	5,783	5,613	6,076	15.6	3.1
FTSE 100	10,414	10,119	10,822	13.8	3.4
TOPIX	3,703	3,539	3,903	17.0	2.3
Shanghai Comp	4,109	4,008	4,203	13.8	2.9
Hang Seng	25,321	24,387	26,827	10.8	3.4
Nifty 50	24,766	23,934	25,970	19.1	1.6
MSCI Asia ex-Japan	977	929	1,039	12.5	2.3
MSCI EM	1,504	1,433	1,600	12.0	2.7
Crude oil (WTI)	81.0	67.4	88.4	na	na
Gold	5,082	4,686	5,449	na	na
UST 10Y Yield	4.14	3.94	4.32	na	na

Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Note: These short-term technical levels are based on models and may differ from a more qualitative analysis provided in other pages

Economic and market calendar

	Market	Event	Period	Expected	Prior
MON	CH	PPI y/y	Feb	-1.1%	-1.4%
	CH	CPI y/y	Feb	0.9%	0.2%
	EC	Sentix Investor Confidence	Mar	–	4.2
TUE	US	NFIB Small Business Optimism	Feb	–	99.3
	US	Existing Home Sales	Feb	3.85m	3.91m
WED	US	CPI y/y	Feb	2.4%	2.4%
	US	Core CPI y/y	Feb	2.4%	2.5%
THU	US	Housing Starts	Jan	1351k	1404k
	US	Building Permits	Jan P	–	–
FRI/SAT	US	Personal Income	Jan	0.4%	0.3%
	US	PCE Price Index y/y	Jan	–	2.9%
	US	Core PCE Price Index y/y	Jan	3.0%	3.0%
	US	Durable Goods Orders	Jan P	1.7%	-1.4%
	US	U. of Mich. Sentiment	Mar P	57.0	56.6
	US	JOLTS Job Openings	Jan	–	6542k

Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Prior data are for the preceding period unless otherwise indicated. Data are % change on previous period unless otherwise indicated

P - preliminary data, F - final data, sa - seasonally adjusted, y/y - year-on-year, m/m - month-on-month

Investor diversity has normalised across asset classes

Our proprietary market diversity indicators as of 5 Mar close

Level 1	Diversity	1-month trend	Fractal dimension
Global Bonds	●	↓	1.51
Global Equities	●	↑	1.69
Gold	●	↑	1.39
Equity			
MSCI US	●	↑	1.92
MSCI Europe	●	↑	1.51
MSCI AC AXJ	●	→	1.44
Fixed Income			
DM Corp Bond	●	↓	1.59
DM High Yield	●	↑	1.53
EM USD	●	→	1.52
EM Local	●	↑	1.57
Asia USD	●	↓	1.52
Currencies			
EUR/USD	●	↑	1.90

Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered; **Fractal dimensions below 1.25 indicate extremely low market diversity/high risk of a reversal**

Legend: ● High | ● Low to mid | ○ Critically low

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Presented by

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Global Chief Investment Officer
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